Putting WKZO on the Map: Mapping and Encoding the Western Michigan at Work Radio Program

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There have been many discussions around how to work with audiovisual collections, particularly in relation to digital humanities work. There are unique problems, such as uneven description in audiovisual collections and a "temporal commitment barrier" that scholars face when working with those collections (Clement / Fisch 2021; Sapienza et al. 2021). Many solutions to these problems have been proposed, from annotation to using convolutional neural networks analyzing spectrograms to various approaches focusing on transcripts (Burges et al. 202; Clement / Fisch 2021; Have / Enevoldsen 2021; Sapienza et al. 2021; Pincemin et al. 2020). "Putting WKZO on the Map," a project developed through the Michigan State University Libraries Digital Scholarship Lab Project Incubator addresses the difficulties of audiovisual collections differently by using a combination of mapping, annotations, and encoded transcripts to highlight places and names of people. In doing so, this project works to situate the collection in context and prepares it for further exploration by scholars and community members alike.

"Putting WKZO on the Map" focuses on a subset of the Kalamazoo Valley Museum WKZO Transcription Disc Collection. The larger collection comprises over 800 transcription discs produced by the Fetzer Broadcasting Corporation and aired over their radio station WKZO in Kalamazoo, MI and its sister station WJEF in Grand Rapids, MI between 1945 to 1956. While these include national network programming ("Aunt Jenny", "Tales of Superman"), they also include a variety of educational programs produced for the local market. This project focuses on one of those programs, "Western Michigan at Work," which features a company or collection of companies around western Michigan in each episode.

"Western Michigan at Work" is well suited to mapping. It consists of approximately 65 episodes of 15 minutes each in which the host gives a history of the company and interviews employees. Audiovisual works possess "unique material forms that exist in cultural contexts and have some social function," and in the case of programming produced by the Fetzer Broadcasting Company that context is the landscape of western Michigan within reach of its radio towers (Burges et al. 2021; Sapienza et al. 2021). Situating the companies, and more importantly the voices of their employees within this landscape helps us to understand the context more broadly: the relationship of companies and industries to the landscape and built environment around them. The project uses historical USGS Topographic Maps as a base layer in ArcGIS to show the historical location of the company when the show aired. The project also categorizes points based on industry (non-automotive manufacturing, paper making, agriculture, etc) and embeds the segments of the program in which the host interviews employees.

Mapping the episodes of "Western Michigan at Work" also aids in discovery, a well known issue with audio materials. While each episode is fully cataloged and accessible through Michigan State University Libraries' catalog and digital repository, it can be difficult to find them alongside thousands of other materials in the catalog. The density and clarity of information given by each point on the map can help patrons quickly navigate and find relevant materials in a more intuitive way than catalogs offer.

The second aspect of the project is to annotate and encode the transcripts of the full programs, marking the names of people and places mentioned in the program using Recogito. This aspect of the project goes beyond the companies highlighted to make visible the employees, community members, and wider industrial landscape represented in the broadcasts. It begins to develop a picture of the communities that would have listened to and been involved with WKZO and WJEF and the communities they served. This creates a robust data set of annotations and transcripts that can be used for further mapping projects, network analyses, and other investigations.

Once the mapping and encoding for "Western Michigan at Work" is complete, the project team will turn to "What's Doing in Western Michigan." This program had the same host and included employees from WKZO reading through local newspapers and highlighting stories from around western Michigan. Instead of each episode focusing

on a single subject, each episode featured multiple stories from the area, which will increase potential networks of people and communities featured in the programs. By encoding and mapping these sets of programs, the project will present an image of the landscape in western Michigan as seen by Fetzer Broadcasting during the late 1940's and early 1950's and give more context to the audio collection. These projects hope to unearth voices and stores from the industrial landscape of Western Michigan and give scholars and patrons a chance to explore them in a variety of contexts and forms.

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